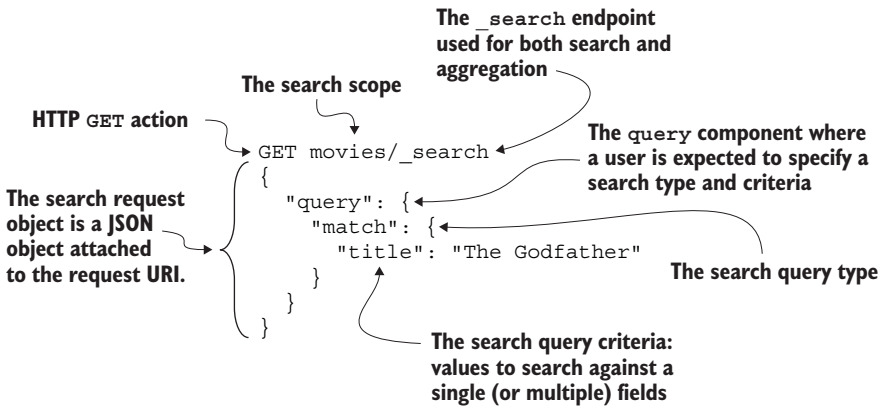


Figure 8.2 Components of a search request

The GET method is the HTTP action that specifies our intention: getting data from the server with the request details carried over in a body. There's a school of thought that the GET method in a RESTful architecture shouldn't send parameters using the body of the request and that instead, we should use a POST method if we are querying the server. But Elasticsearch implements the GET method request that accepts a body, which helps formulate the query parameters. We can replace GET with POST, as both GET or POST act on the resource the same way.

> **NOTE** The internet is full of hot debates about using GET with and without a payload. Elasticsearch takes the route of using GET with a payload. (If you want to understand the schools of thought, search for "HTTP get with body" on the internet). In this book, we use GET with a payload for search and aggregation queries, although you can replace GET with POST if you are not comfortable using the GET method with a body.

The search scope in the GET (or POST) action defines the index or an alias that the engine uses to carry out the search. We can also include multiple indexes, multiple aliases, or no index in this URL. To specify multiple indexes (or aliases), enter comma-separated index (or alias) names. Providing no index or alias on the search request tells the search to run against all the indexes across the cluster. For example, if we have a cluster with 10 indexes, running a search query like `GET _search {...}` without specifying index or alias names searches for all matching documents against all 10 indexes.

The search request object or payload is a JSON object enclosing the request details. The request details include the `query` component and can include other components such as pagination-related `size` and `form` attributes, a list that indicates which source fields to return in the response, sort criteria, highlighting, and so forth. We discuss individual features later in this chapter.